

CHAPTER 8

CREATING PROSPERITY FOR GENERATIONS

We have looked at how you get and keep money. And we've looked at how you get and keep a family, too. Now we consider how you get and keep the family and the money working together, helping each other to flourish. In order to turn your new money into Old Money, you will need a special kind of family, the kind that can handle family money through multiple generations.

How do you do that? Wish we knew! What we do know is that few families are able to pull it off. But some families are extremely successful at it.

Take the Kongo family of Japan.

Founded in 578, Japanese temple builder Kongo Gumi is a family business that has lasted for 14 centuries.¹ Its last president, Masakazu Kongo, was the 40th member of the family to lead the company.

This family business built Buddhist temples and many other famous buildings in Japan, for over 1,400 years. The Kongo family business has been around longer than most countries of the world. (For instance, modern-day Switzerland wasn't founded until 1291.)

The secret to this longevity is having secrets—valuable secrets.

Each generation passed on the traditions and secrets of temple building. The family also passed on a unique construction method called *kumiage koho*, a precision woodworking technique that is part of Japanese cultural heritage. They don't use any nails.

Each generation of Kongo children had to have a comprehensive knowledge of woods—right down to knowing how the temperature and humidity of various microclimates affect wood over time. These techniques